

KOMBUCHA

This age-old fermented tea has become quite popular as a homebrew. Fizzy and slightly alcoholic, Kombucha has a sweet and sour taste that is clean and refreshing. With bacterial flora and healthy acids that promote intestinal health, this probiotic drink can be consumed as a daily tonic.

The origins of Kombucha can be traced back to China during the Han Dynasty (206BCE–25CE). From there it made its way to Russia through Mongolia in the 19th century. Around 1910, Kombucha arrived in Eastern Europe and was popular in Germany between the first and second World Wars, but became less so due to the scarcity of sugar and tea during WWII. Interest in Kombucha was revived in Europe and America during the 1990s and it has since become a popular beverage among homebrewers.

Kombucha is made by fermenting sweetened black or green tea with a culture of yeast and beneficial bacteria called a “kombucha mushroom,” or SCOBY (see box, below). As the yeast in the SCOBY consumes the sugary tea, it produces a small amount of alcohol (less than 1 percent) and CO₂ as by-products, which give Kombucha its sparkle. Although the alcohol content is very low, it is not recommended for children, pregnant women, or nursing mothers.

DRINK TWO OR THREE
SMALL GLASSES A DAY
TO REAP THE HEALTH
BENEFITS OF KOMBUCHA

THE SCOBY

The living ingredient in Kombucha is the SCOBY, an acronym for Symbiotic Colony Of Bacteria and Yeast. The SCOBY is similar to “mother of vinegar,” the jelly-like layer that forms on top of apple cider vinegar and gives it sourness, but is much more solid. Slimy in texture and beige in color, it will take on the shape of the container in which it is cultured. It requires the right conditions to turn tea and sugar into acetic acid (colorless liquid with an acidic taste) through fermentation. The SCOBY, or Kombucha liquid, should never come into contact with metal of any sort since the chemical reaction will damage the SCOBY and the culture in the liquid.



Assam tea